Unseen City Canvases:
Exploring Blind and Low Vision People's Perspectives on Urban and Public Art Accessibility

Project Website

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Problem & Motivation

Despite its cultural benefits, urban art is not accessible to blind and low vision (BLV) people due to **discovery and engagement** barriers.

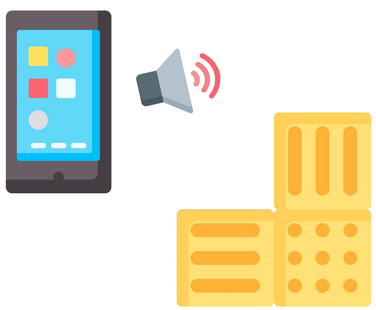
Prior work has explored art access in museums and accessible navigation in urban spaces, but there remains a gap at the intersection of these two fields: **urban art accessibility** research.

Methodology

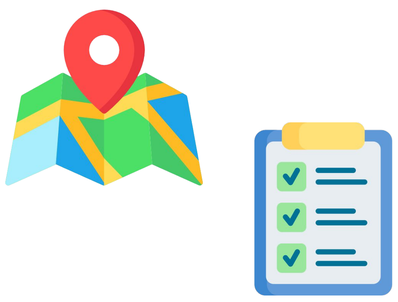
- Defined a **seven-dimensional design space** for urban and public art accessibility
- Interviewed **16 BLV people** with varying urban art experience
- Conducted a design exploration with diverse **urban art probes** (including AI-generated descriptions and real-time chat interactions)

Findings: Urban Artwork Poses Distinct Challenges

Discovery Considerations: Spontaneous Notifications & Artwork Databases

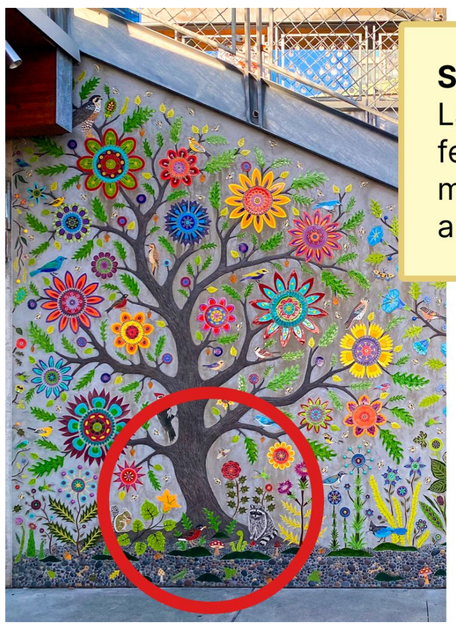


- Notifications approximate a sense of surprise
- Could take the form of auditory cues / tactile paving



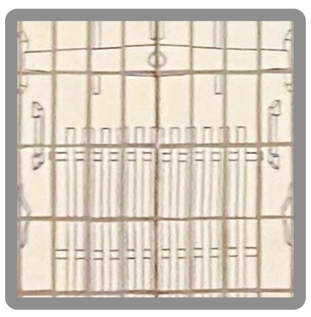
- Pre-planning visits is invaluable for access
- Could take the form of maps or databases

Description Considerations: Environmental Integration & Cultural Significance

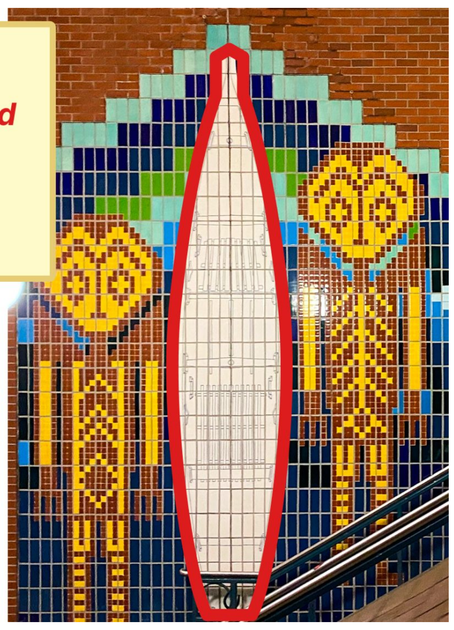


Short description:
Large-scale ***mural*** beneath a stairway featuring vibrant tree of life with colorful mandala-like flowers, birds, and wildlife on a concrete wall.





Short description:
Large subway tile mosaic depicting ***stylized city elements with a white rocket shape***, yellow totems, and blue background alongside a staircase.



If you're interested in the accessibility of **subjective information** (e.g., videos, images, art), please reach out – I'd love to chat!

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